PocketToons

Investigation report

Where does the paywall funnel lose users?

Where do users drop from viewing a paywall to starting checkout and purchasing?

Data

PocketToons SQLite synthetic fixture
April–September 2026 UTC

Snapshot

2026-09-30 23:59:59 UTC (metadata)
Build 3a0dbed21d2f45958aefa2887a0cadd8

Run

Independent
2026-11-09
14 logged checks

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How to read this report

- Checks refer to the numbered JSONL evidence files in the run directory.
- The registered funnel counts paywall events, not distinct people.
- Observed links and associations do not prove causes.

Terms used in this report

Term	Meaning
Checkout	A checkout event explicitly linked to the paywall.
Purchase	A linked, successful valid charge; a later refund does not undo this count.
PPV	Pay-per-view.

01. Chapter

The answer

01

The biggest observed gap is before checkout: 3,824 of 7,221 paywall views (53.0%) had no linked checkout. A further 1,804 of 3,397 linked checkout paywalls (53.1%) had no linked successful purchase (checks 4–7).

7,221

Paywall views

3,397

Linked checkout paywalls
47.0% of views

1,593

Linked purchase paywalls
22.1% of views

- Subscription paywalls account for 87.4% of views and 87.5% of the pre-checkout losses (check 5).
- April has much higher conversion than May–September; investigate the change in subscription flow and instrumentation before attributing a cause (checks 4, 8, 11).
- Uncaptured links and the incomplete follow-up at the end of September mean these are observed funnel losses, not proof of abandonment.

02. Chapter

How we investigated

02

What data we used

- Independent investigation; authorized PocketToons SQLite, read-only. April 1 through October 1, 2026 UTC, half-open; paywalls grouped by event month.
- Approved paywall_funnel v1.0: one view is one funnel unit. Multiple checkouts or payment attempts per paywall count once. Purchases are credited through recorded checkout links; later refunds do not reverse conversion.
- Gold monthly funnel fits the approved definition; Silver and Bronze check detail and traceability. Build 3a0dbed21d2f45958aefa2887a0cadd8 succeeded November 9; metadata snapshot is September 30, 23:59:59 UTC (checks 1–3).
- Synthetic reference fixture; metadata timestamp is an asserted snapshot, not a verified whole-file hash.

Investigation path

- Baseline and product decomposition: Gold, independently compared with Silver (checks 4, 5, 7).
- Round 1: product differences; payment-attempt evidence; end-of-coverage sensitivity (checks 8, 11, 14). Stop: further mechanism claims require instrumentation or product context.

03. Chapter

What happened

03

The movement

UTC month	Views	Checkout	Purchase	View to purchase
Apr	1,935	1,257	937	48.4%
May	1,088	455	160	14.7%
Jun	1,023	399	102	10.0%
Jul	1,069	428	140	13.1%
Aug	1,026	421	102	9.9%
Sep	1,080	437	152	14.1%

- Each later step is credited to the paywall month; September can be right-censored. Rates combine counts, never averages of monthly rates (check 4).

Who drove it

Product	Views	Checkout	Purchase	No checkout
Subscription	6,311	2,965	1,394	3,346
PPV	910	432	199	478
All	7,221	3,397	1,593	3,824

- Subscription: 47.0% reached checkout; 47.0% of those reached purchase. PPV: 47.5% reached checkout; 46.1% of those reached purchase. Aggregate rates mask a large shift over time (checks 4–5).
- In April, subscription purchase per view was 50.6% (902/1,781); in May–September it was 10.9% (492/4,530). PPV was 22.7% in April and 21.7% thereafter (check 11). These are associations, not causal decompositions.

04. Chapter

Why it happened

04

Hypothesis	Status	Evidence
Subscription conversion shifted after April	Supported pattern	Both steps worsened: checkout/view 66.3% to 39.4%; purchase/checkout 76.4% to 27.6% in May–September. Cause unknown (checks 4, 11).
Failed recorded attempts explain most checkout losses	Rejected as recorded pattern	Subscription has 1,571 checkout paywalls without purchase and zero linked failed attempts; PPV has 233 such paywalls and 29 with a linked failed attempt. Missing attempts can reflect missing telemetry (check 8).
September tail is fully observed	Inconclusive	Sept 24–30: 10/204 purchased vs 142/876 earlier in September; timing or population may differ. No fixed lag is guaranteed (check 14).

05. Chapter

Data quality and limits

05

Data quality

- 175 of 3,572 checkout events (4.9%) have no captured paywall link; 56 of 1,725 in-app successful purchases (3.2%) have no checkout link. Counts use checkout/purchase month, not paywall cohort, so do not add them to the funnel or infer attribution (checks 6, 13).
- All 7,221 paywalls have distinct event IDs, identified users and no Silver exceptions; 3,646 distinct viewers make clear that events are not people (checks 5, 9). Source event count matches the build record, but no current content fingerprint was recomputed (checks 3, 12).
- Build-reported builder SHA matches local code; build registry SHA 57b21d... differs from current registry SHA 4b5b2f... . Both report funnel version 1.0, but the difference is unresolved; build-time reconciliation does not establish that the source or definitions are unchanged now (check 3).
- Metadata snapshots end September 30; the last month is susceptible to delayed outcomes. No evidence establishes causality or telemetry completeness.

06. Chapter

What to do next

06

01 Audit subscription paywall and checkout changes around April–May, including event and transaction link capture; reconcile instrumentation with payment provider records.

02 Instrument checkout steps, exits, errors and payment initiation; monitor the two stage rates and missing-link rates by product and cohort.

03 Re-run on a later verified snapshot with a defined follow-up window, particularly for September; compare mature cohorts before concluding the late-month drop is behavioral.

04 Resolve the registry hash mismatch and recompute source fingerprints before relying on the build as current.

Appendix

Evidence appendix

A

- Checks 01–03: table inventory, metadata and build/reconciliation.
- Checks 04–07: monthly funnel, product totals, source coverage and Silver reconciliation.
- Checks 08–11: attempts, key quality, event tail and period/product comparison.
- Checks 12–14: source row count, unlinked purchases and late-September sensitivity.
- Full SQL, parameters, timestamps, returned rows and truncation status are retained in separate JSONL files. All 14 checks succeeded without truncation.